

Riva Lehrer

Riva Lehrer is an artist, writer and curator who focuses on the socially challenged body. She is best known for representations of people whose physical embodiment, sexuality, or gender identity have long been stigmatized. Riva's work has been seen in venues including the National Portrait Gallery of the Smithsonian, Yale University, the United Nations, the National Museum of Women in the Arts in Washington, DC, the Annet Museum, the DeCordova Museum, the Frye Museum, the Chicago Cultural Center, and the State of Illinois Museum. Riva is on faculty at the School of the Art Institute of Chicago, and instructor in the Medical Humanities Departments of Northwestern University.

The Risk Pictures | *In The Risk Pictures, my collaborators and I experiment most strongly with the traditional relationship between artist and subject. People who live in stigmatized bodies are often made to feel ashamed. They—we—labor under a judgmental, aggressive public gaze turned in our direction. I am very aware that sitting for a portrait is a vulnerable experience. The subject agrees to be stared at for hours at a time. The traditional dynamic either defines that the artist as examiner, one who wields more power than the subject. Yet, if the portrait is a commission, it is the subject who holds the (economic) power. It's rarely an equal dynamic. (That said, few of my portraits are commissions.) In The Risk Pictures, I aim to make myself as vulnerable as my subject. My collaborators come to my studio (in my house) for at least five three-hour sittings. At the two-hour mark, I leave for at least one hour. My subject has complete control of my home. They have my permission to do anything they want. They might eat my food, sleep in my bed, snore through my belongings, even steal what they want. My promise is that I'll never ask what they did. Their commitment, in exchange, is that they must alter their own portrait while I'm gone. I provide all my art supplies, with only technical guidance. I am not allowed to erase what they do, only respond to it. We repeat this process till the work is complete. The final piece is signed by both of us.*

Alice Sheppard is the Founder and Artistic Director of Kinetic Light, as well as a choreographer and dancer in the company. Sheppard has a PhD in Medieval Studies from Cornell University and was previously an associate professor of English at Penn State University. Sheppard references what she considers the "pleasure of reckless abandon," preferring not to emphasize the impairment aspect of her work; rather, incorporating wheelchairs, crutches, and other tools for mobility into her choreography as unexpected markers that distinguish her often conventional, classical dance movement with those, as she explains, "arising directly from impairment."